who comprise archetypal, critical American Berliners who seek knowledge in relationship to broader questions of their own transnational identities and relationship to freedom. After a first visit to Berlin, these artists, writers, and activists generally returned to divided Germany many times, as a matter of ritual, while the Wall was still up and—without foreseeable anticipation of such a moment—after its dismantling. Their travels often shaped career-long projects and significant modes of inquiry in Germany that probed profound questions about American identity, belonging, and democracy. The Berlin Wall served as a point of entry to access the liminal spaces and fault lines of each nation and thereby to theorize about matters of identity. These American Berliners saw their own country with greater depth after visiting Berlin, worked through their own aesthetic and intellectual issues in the city, and modeled engaged forms of cultural diplomacy. The American Berliners at the center of this book—Leonard Freed, Angela Davis, Shinkichi Tajiri, and Audre Lorde—present a complex rendering of divided Berlin from the periods they spent in the city during the Cold War, their itineraries after visiting Berlin, and their return journeys after the Wall was dismantled. This book treats their stories as a means of approaching divided Berlin as a site to explore intersectional identities, to survey U.S. power through cultural tools, and to summon strategies for coexistence, including those birthed along the fault lines of the city. Their travels and critical thinking correspond to those of others who fit into this larger shared history of encounter in Berlin, including Louis Armstrong, Paul Beatty, Jonathan Borofsky, David Bowie, Christo and Jeanne-Claude, Frank Hallam Day, Jeffrey Eugenides, Allen Frame, Jonathan Franzen, Nan Goldin, John Gossage, Andrew Sean Greer, Langston Hughes, Keith Haring, Oliver Harrington, Michael Jackson, Allan Kaprow, Martin Luther King Jr., Gordon Matta Clark, Joyce Carol Oates, John Cameron Mitchell, Darryl Pinckney, Adrian Piper, Iggy Pop, Paul Robeson, Stew, Stephanie Syjuco, Bill Van Parys, Lawrence Weiner, Billy Wilder, and countless other traveling practitioners.[20] Such individuals produced works that treated the Berlin Wall as a site of gravity as well as a place to pivot, channeling their experiences near the Wall into narratives that jointly troubled Cold War politics at home and abroad. Similarly, as Claudia Mesch notes of West and East German artists during the Cold War, American cultural producers channeled aesthetic questions and practices through “international cultural exchange and the flow of culture across the [inner-German] border.”[21]